

Session 6: Isaac Deceives Abimelech

Key Takeaways

- God renews his promise to Yitskhaq, echoing the covenants made to previous generations.
- The unusual phrase “on the heel of” means “because.” It recalls the heel of the snake crusher in Genesis 3:15, while keeping Yaaqov the heel grabber on our minds as the story focuses on his father.
- Yitskhaq imitates the deceitful schemes of his father. And instead of blessing the world around him, he brings danger to Abimelech and his people.

The Story of Yitskhaq

The literary design of this unit has been carefully crafted to invite the reader into a meditation on how the children repeat the story of their parents, and how God’s choice of this family means that God’s justice and mercy will also repeat through the generations.

Genesis 26:1-6

- **Famine, journey to Gerar, God’s covenant promise of blessing, seed, and land**

Genesis 26:7-11

- **Yitskhaq’s fear and deception of the Philistines** that puts Rivqah at risk, Avimelek’s noble response

Genesis 26:12-14

- **Yitskhaq’s abundance of seed, land, and possessions from God’s blessing**
- **Yitskhaq sows seed “in that land” (בארץ ההוא) and “finds” (מצא) 100 measures and many servants (עבדה)**

Genesis 26:15-31

- **26:15-25 Disputes with Philistines** over wells, promise of **divine blessing**
- **26:26-31 Dispute with Philistines** resolved through a **covenant oath**, Avimelek’s noble response

Genesis 26:32-33

- Yitskhaq's servants "in that time" (ביום ההוא) "find" (מצא) a well of water that they name "Seven" (שבע)

Genesis 26:1-33. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Summary of Genesis 26:1-14

The opening and closing units form an Eden blessing frame around the story of Yitskhaq's deception, in which he puts the promise of future seed at risk through his fear.

This juxtaposition emphasizes a contrast between God's promise and provision of abundance in the outer frames and the fear, self-preservation, and deception of Yitskhaq in the center.

Notice that in contrast to the parallel story of Abraham and Abimelech in Genesis 20, here God does not appear in the story to tell Abimelech about the true identity of the woman with Yitskhaq. Instead, he finds out on his own, as he gazes out from a tall window.

The Hinge Role

From this perspective, Genesis 26:12-14 forms a concluding frame around the deception story that links back up to Genesis 26:1-6. However, the final line of 26:14 and the keyword links of 26:12-14 show that 26:12-14 is a mirror unit that simultaneously concludes 26:1-14 and introduces the large unit to follow in Genesis 26:12-33.

The transitional unit of 26:12-14 functions as a concluding frame around 26:1-14 and as an introductory frame that spans from 26:12-33.

Yitskhaq's Deception of Abimelech

¹ And there was a **famine** in **the land** ,
besides the first **famine** which was in the days of **Abraham** ,
and Yitskhaq went (הלך) to Abimelek the king of the Philistines **at Gerar** .

² And Yahweh appeared to him,
and he said,

"Don't go down to Egypt!
Dwell in **the land** which I say to you.

³ Migrate in **this land** ,
and I will be with you
and **I will bless you** ,
because to you and to **your seed** I will give all **these lands** ,
and I will establish my oath which I swore to **Abraham** your father,

⁴ and I will multiply **your seed** like the stars of the skies,
and I will give to your seed all **these lands** ,

and **all the nations** of **the land** **will find blessing** for themselves through **your seed** ,

⁵ on the heel of the fact that **Abraham** listened to my voice,
and he kept my keeping, my command, my statute, and my instruction."

⁶ **And Yitskhaq stayed in Gerar** .

⁷ And **the men of the place** asked about **his wife** ,

and **he said** ,

" **She is my sister** ; "

A for he was afraid to say,

" **my wife** . "

" **So that the men of the place** don't **murder me on account of Rivqah** ,
for she is good of sight."

⁸ And it came about, when the days for him there were long,

B that **Abimelech** king of the Philistines looked down through a window,
and he saw, and look: Yitskhaq was **playing with his wife** Rivqah.

⁹ And **Abimelech** called Yitskhaq and he said, "Behold, certainly she is **your wife** !

And how then did **you say** ,

' **She is my sister** '?"

A' And Yitskhaq said to him,

"Because I said,

' **So that I don't die on account of her** . "

¹⁰ And **Abimelech** said,

"What is this you have done to us?

B' One of **the people** might easily **have laid with your wife** ,
and you would have brought guilt upon us."

¹¹ And **Abimelech** commanded all **the people**, saying,

"He who touches this man or **his wife** shall surely be put to death."

¹² And Yitskhaq **sowed seed (זרע)** in **that land**
and he found in the same year a hundred **measures (שערים)** ,
and **Yahweh blessed him** ,

¹³ and the man became **great** ,
and he went on (ילך הלך) growing **great**
until he became very **great** ;

¹⁴ and he had herds of flocks and herds of cattle and many servants,

and the **Philistines** envied him.

Genesis 26:1-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

God's Blessing and Oath

God's initial words to Yitskhaq are a blend of all the previous blessing promises in Genesis, with a special focus on the promises to Abraham.

God's Promise to Yitskhaq (Genesis 26:2-5)	God's Promises to Avraham
² Dwell in the land which I say to you . ^{3a} Migrate in this land , and I will be with you and I will bless you ,	Gen. 12:1-2 Go forth from your land, and from your family, and from your father's house, to the land which I will make seen to you ; and I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you .
^{3b} because to you and to your seed I will give all these lands ,	Gen. 12:7 And Yahweh became seen to Avram and he said, "To your seed I will give this land ." Gen. 13:15 For all the land that you see, to you I will give it, and to your seed , forever.
and I will establish my oath which I swore to Avraham your father,	Gen. 22:16 I swear an oath by myself, utterance of Yahweh, that on account of the fact that you did this thing,
⁴ and I will multiply your seed like the stars of the skies , and I will give to your seed all these lands ,	Gen. 13:16 And I will make your seed like the dust of the land , which, if one was able to count the dust of the land , then also your seed could be counted. Gen. 22:17 that I will certainly bless you, and I will certainly multiply your seed , like the stars of the skies ,
and all the nations of the land will find blessing for themselves through your seed , ⁵ on the heel of the fact that Avraham listened to	Gen. 12:3 ... and in you all the families of the earth will be blessed .

God's Blessing and Oath. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

God's Promise to Yitskhaq (Genesis 26:2-5)	God's Promises to Avraham
my voice , and he kept my keeping, my command, my statute, and my instruction.	Gen. 22:18 and all the nations of the land will find blessing in your seed , on the heel of the fact that he listened to my voice .
God's Blessing and Oath. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

God’s words to Yitskhaq are a careful blend of nearly all of God’s promise speeches to Abraham. Clearly, the divine blessing for Abraham is now being passed onto Yitskhaq, and Yitskhaq, in turn, will pass it on to his sons.

It’s important to remember that this divine blessing takes us all the way back to the creation narrative of Genesis, where humanity was given the initial creation blessing and invitation to co-rule the world as God’s image. This role was forfeited and then passed on to Noah, and now to the family of Abraham.

Humanity	Noah and Family	Avraham and Sarah	Yitskhaq and Rivqah	Yaaqov and Esau
Gen. 1:26-28 “Be fruitful and multiply, fill the land and subdue it ... rule over the creatures ...”	Gen. 9:1-17 “Be fruitful and multiply, fill the land.”	Gen. 12:1-3; 13:15-18; 15; 17; 22:12-17	Gen. 26:1-5	Gen. 27
Be Fruitful and Multiply. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).				

Like Father, Like Son; Unlike Father, Unlike Son

Yitskhaq is replaying [Genesis 12](#), and he is both unlike (he doesn’t go to Egypt) and like his father (he gives away Rivqah).

Yitskhaq in Genesis 26	Avraham in Genesis 20-21	Avram in Genesis 12-13
Gen. 26:1-5 God’s blessing on Yitskhaq		Gen. 13:1-6 God’s blessing on Avram
Yitskhaq Compared to Avraham. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

Yitskhaq in Genesis 26	Avraham in Genesis 20-21	Avram in Genesis 12-13
Famine in the land, “Don’t go down to Egypt,” Yitskhaq goes to Gerar ruled by Avimelek.	Avraham goes to Gerar ruled by Avimelek.	Famine in the land, Avram goes down to Egypt ruled by Pharaoh.
Yitskhaq fears for his life, and deceives the Philistines about his wife. Gen. 26:7 And he said, “She is my sister” for he was afraid to say “my wife,” “Lest they kill me ... on account of Rebekah, for she is good of sight.”	Avraham fears for his life, and deceives the Philistines about his wife. Gen. 20:2 And Avraham said of Sarah his wife, “She is my sister.”	Avram fears for his life, and deceives the Egyptians about his wife. Gen. 12:11-13 And he said to Sarai his wife, “Look now I know that you are a woman beautiful of sight ... the Egyptians ... will kill me and let you live. Say you are my sister.”
King Avimelek finds out and confronts Yitskhaq. Gen. 26:10 “What is this you have done to us?”	King Avimelek finds out and confronts Avraham. Gen. 20:9 “What have you done to us?”	King of Egypt finds out and confronts Avram. Gen. 12:18 “What is this you have done to me?”
Gen. 26:11 And Avimelek commanded all the people saying, “the one who touches (נגע) her will surely die.”	Gen. 20:6-7 “I have not given you to touch (נגע) her ... And if you do not return her, know that you will surely die.”	Gen. 12:20 And Pharaoh gave a command concerning him, and they sent away him and his wife Gen. 12:17 And Yahweh struck (נגע) Pharaoh with great strikes (נגע)
Yitskhaq Compared to Avraham. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

The Garden All Over Again

All three of these narratives follow a promise of great blessing for God’s chosen one, and all three are filled with hyperlinks to the Eden failure story in [Genesis 2-3](#).

- God provides trees in Eden that are “good of sight and desirable for eating.”
- God warns about one forbidden tree that will kill them: “You will surely die.”
- The snake deceives the woman and the man about the tree: “You will not die.”
- The woman says the forbidden tree “is not to be touched.”
- God asks the humans, “What is this you have done?”

The point: Yitskhaq replays the failure of his father and the failure of Adam and Eve in the garden. The son is a deceiver, just like his father.

But notice, Yitskhaq's deception and failure story has been placed after Yaaqov's deception story. This links together all three generations of God's chosen ones in a pattern of deception and failure: like father, like son, like grandson!

Reflection Question

How does Yitskhaq's deception threaten God's plan to bring blessing through Yitskhaq and his descendants?